

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1989-11-09

1 dear bahá'í friends,
2 about your laudable desire to simplify enrollment procedures and eliminate obstacles
to new believers' joining the bahá'í community. it has asked us to
3 send you the following reply.
4 first, the house of justice does not believe that the by-laws of a local
5 Spiritual Assembly are intended to imply by the term "voting membership" that
there are two classes of membership in the bahá'í community, except
6 insofar as those under the age of 21 do not have the right to vote or serve on

a Spiritual Assembly.77 .1

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78 2
79 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e
80 16As you well understand, there is no universally applicable procedure that
81 a new believer must follow in making a declaration of faith. in essence, it
82 is simply the act of making it known to the bahá'ís that he too believes in
83 bahá'u'lláh, accepts the faith, and wishes to be recognized as a member of
the bahá'í community. The process of considering and accepting such a
84 declaration by the institutions of the faith or their duly appointed represen-
85 tatives should follow as swiftly as possible. The procedure for this is left to
86 the discretion of each National Spiritual Assembly, and can vary from area to area
within the same country.
87 As you indicate in your letter, the process of issuing an enrollment card
88 is a separate, purely formal, step that follows the above decision.
89 whether a newly declared bahá'í should be invited to attend a Nineteen
90 day feast before his declaration has been accepted is a matter at the discre-
91 tion of the local Spiritual Assembly in light of the specific circumstances.
92 for example, where feasible, could the Assembly not provide that, if a decla-

93 ration is made so soon before a feast that the Assembly has no time to meet
94 to accept it, the officers would be authorized to welcome the new believer
95 to the feast unless they have some reason for doubting that the declaration
96 would be accepted? in general it would seem to be better to show a lov-
97 ing and welcoming spirit rather than to stand on a point of administrative
98 procedure.
99 with loving b ahá'í greetings,

Department of tHe secretariat

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**A National Spiritual Assembly's Relations
with Government**

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]